

best laptops of its time, used a 4.7MHz Intel processor and 512KB of RAM and ran MS-DOS. (The display was a two-color dot-matrix display). As technology progressed, power efficient chips were developed (particularly the Intel Centrino series of chips) and were instrumental in popularizing the use of laptop computers. Apart from superior power management, they also standardized wireless adapters that enabled them to connect to wireless networks on the go, thus turning laptops into a complete replacement for traditional desktops, with the added advantage of mobility.

The precursor to today's smartphones, PDAs or Personal Digital Assistants were very popular, especially with business users who needed an ultra portable computer without compromising on the essential features. PDAs function as Personal Information Managers (PIMs), meaning they combine the functions of a planner, organizer and a phone into one device, often with internet connectivity via data networks or Wi-Fi for tasks like sending and receiving emails or browsing the web. Larger screens with touchscreen input or a full QWERTY keypad were synonymous with PDAs. Devices running on Palm or Windows Mobile typically used touch screens with handwriting recognition and a stylus for data input, while Blackberry popularized the physical QWERTY keypad. Some of the higher end products came with built in GPS radios for navigation capabilities and SD cards for storing digital media such as music and video files. Most had the ability to sync with a desktop computer, so data could be easily shared between the two devices. Though syncing with the cloud was still absent, syncing with one's PC had three valuable advantages. One was that the user data was automatically copied to both devices, eliminating the need for manually entering the data twice. Second, that in case one's PDA was lost or stolen, the data could be restored by simply re-syncing it with the desktop. Since data entry was slightly uncomfortable due to the cramped (virtual or physical)



Apple's MessagePad was far ahead of its time